**Interview Questions & Strategies**

**Purpose** – fast, night-before revision: the highest-frequency interview questions, grouped by theme, plus compact answer frameworks and delivery tips.

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**Quick index**

Motivation & Fit – Skills & Strengths – Problem-Solving – Communication – Learning – Technical

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## 1 How to use this sheet

1. **Scan** the theme you'll likely face.
2. **Draft** bullet-point answers using the framework shown.
3. **Time** yourself – aim for 90–120 seconds per answer.
4. **Record & review** – tighten wording, trim filler.

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## 2 Framework Cheat Card

| Framework | Mnemonic | Sample opener |
|---|---|---|
| **STARL** | *Situation → Task → Action → Result → Lesson* | "During my summer job at Tesco **(Situation)**, I was tasked with reorganising the stockroom **(Task)**..." |
| **WHY-YOU / WHY-US** | *Why are **you** suited? Why this **company**?* | "I thrive in data-driven teams, and your recent £50 m AI initiative aligns with my Python-based analytics work..." |
| **CAR** | *Challenge → Action → Result* | "A teammate dropped out 48 h before our deadline, so I split the remaining workload and..." |
| **PEARL** | *Point → Evidence → Analysis → Link-back* | "The biggest fintech risk is cyber-resilience. Last year £x bn was lost... therefore ..." |

**Tip:** Signal your structure aloud ("The challenge was...").

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## 3 Question Bank

### 3.1 Motivation & Fit

Why this **role**? • Why **our company**? • Why a **degree apprenticeship** over university? • Where do you see yourself in **five years**?

**Sample STARL answer (condensed)**
*Situation* – "During Year 12 I led a coding club but realised theory alone wasn't satisfying me. *Task* – I wanted a path combining real engineering with a funded degree. *Action* –

Researched schemes and saw your firm's cloud-migration apprenticeship, spoke to a current apprentice on LinkedIn, attended your insight evening. *Result* – Confirmed the culture fits my team-oriented style and I can contribute Python tooling from day one. *Lesson* – Hands-on learning accelerates my growth; that's why this apprenticeship at **Company X** beats the traditional university route for me.

### 3.2 Skills & Strengths

Tell me about a time you **worked in a team**. • Example of **leadership** under pressure. • How will you **balance working and studying**? • Your **greatest strength** (with evidence).

### 3.3 Problem-Solving & Adaptability

Describe a major **challenge** you overcame. • Task with a significant **obstacle** and how you handled it. • Biggest **change** you've adapted to. • Task you'd **never done before** – approach?

**Sample STARL answer (condensed)**
*Situation* – "Hackathon: API outage 4 h before demo." *Task* – Restore service & still present a working product. *Action* – Spun up a mock server in Flask, rewrote fetch calls, delegated UI work to teammate. *Result* – Demo succeeded; judges praised resilience; team won 2nd place. *Lesson* – Build contingency plans early and communicate roles clearly under pressure.

### 3.4 Communication & Persuasion

Example of **persuading** someone. • Presenting a **complex idea** to non-experts. • Dealing with a **difficult stakeholder**.

### 3.5 Learning & Reflection

Mistake you **learned** from. • Feedback you **implemented**. • A **weakness** you're addressing.

### 3.6 Technical / Role-specific probes

Walk through a **favourite project**. • Explain **object-oriented programming** to a layperson. • How would you design a **scalable login system**?

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## 4 Delivery Tips (from successful ACs & interviews)

| Focus | Practical tip |
|---|---|
| Eye-contact & posture | Aim for ~70 % eye-contact; sit upright, slight forward lean. |
| Clarify if unsure | Politely ask for the question again rather than guessing. |
| 60-second hook | Prepare a concise intro: name, study area, signature project – interviewers often build on it. |
| Pause & structure | Sip water, collect thoughts, then answer in framework order to avoid filler words. |

| Focus | Practical tip |
| --- | --- |
| Reflect after each stage | Note what landed well and feed improvements into the next interview. |

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🚀 **15-Minute Drill**

1. Pick **one theme** above.
2. Draft **two answers** using STARL (or relevant framework).
3. Record yourself – aim for 90–120 s, play back, tighten.
4. Switch to the next theme; repeat.

Repeat nightly during interview week to internalise stories and timing.

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